Public Speaking and Communication Skills

Introduction

Public speaking is the skill of speaking to a group of people in a structured, deliberate way to inform, persuade or entertain them. Communication skills, more broadly, include speaking, listening, writing and non-verbal signals. These skills are among the most valued by employers, and surveys of recruiters regularly rank communication as one of the top qualities sought in graduates. Good communication helps in interviews, presentations, group discussions, leadership, teamwork and everyday relationships. Famous speakers include Swami Vivekananda, whose speech opening with the words "Sisters and brothers of America" at the World's Parliament of Religions in Chicago on 11 September 1893 earned a standing ovation, Mahatma Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru and Dr. A. P. J. Abdul Kalam, who was a beloved speaker among students. Public speaking is a skill that can be learned by anyone with practice.

The Communication Process

Communication has a sender, a message, a channel, a receiver and feedback. Barriers include noise, language differences, assumptions, emotions and poor listening. The "7 Cs" of effective communication are clear, concise, concrete, correct, coherent, complete and courteous. Communication can be verbal (words, tone, pace, volume), non-verbal (body language, gestures, facial expressions), written and visual.

How Can You Reduce Stage Fear?

Stage fear, or fear of public speaking, is called glossophobia, and it is extremely common: surveys suggest that a large share of people feel anxious about speaking in public. It is normal to feel nervous, as it is the body's fight-or-flight response, and even experienced speakers get butterflies. The goal is to manage it, not to eliminate it. Effective ways to reduce stage fear are as follows. Prepare thoroughly: know your topic well, organise the content and prepare notes or an outline; confidence comes from preparation. Practise repeatedly: rehearse aloud, in front of a mirror, record yourself on video, and practise before friends or family, and time your talk. Use deep breathing: breathe slowly in through the nose for four counts and out for six before going on stage. Visualise success and use positive self-talk, reminding yourself that the audience wants you to succeed. Arrive early to see the room and the equipment. Start strongly with a story, a question or an interesting fact, and memorise the first few sentences. Focus on your message and audience rather than on yourself. Make eye contact with friendly faces. Pause when needed, since silence feels longer to you than to the audience, and drink water. Accept mistakes and carry on, as audiences rarely notice them. Gain experience gradually by speaking in class, taking part in debates, and joining clubs such as Toastmasters International, founded in 1924 by Ralph Smedley, which has many clubs in Chennai, and college literary associations. Regular exposure is the best cure.

What Is Body Language?

Body language is non-verbal communication, the messages we send through our posture, gestures, facial expressions, eye contact, movement, appearance and touch, as opposed to words. It strongly affects how the audience perceives the speaker's confidence and sincerity. Positive body language includes standing straight with shoulders back, a relaxed and open posture, a genuine smile, steady eye contact with different people across the room, natural hand gestures that emphasise points, purposeful movement and a firm handshake. Negative body language includes slouching, crossing the arms, avoiding eye contact, fidgeting, putting hands in pockets, pacing nervously, turning your back to the audience and reading from slides. Voice is also part of delivery: speak clearly at a moderate pace, vary your tone and volume, avoid filler words like "um" and "you know", and use pauses for emphasis. The researcher Albert Mehrabian's studies of 1967 are often misquoted to say that communication is only 7 percent words, but his findings applied only to feelings and attitudes when words and body language conflict; the point remains that non-verbal cues matter a great deal. Body language also differs across cultures: for example, in India, a head wobble can mean agreement.

What Are the Parts of a Good Presentation?

A good presentation has three main parts: the introduction, the body and the conclusion, often followed by a question and answer session. The old advice is "tell them what you are going to say, say it, and then tell them what you said". The introduction opens with an attention-grabbing hook, such as a story, a question, a surprising statistic or a quote, introduces yourself and the topic, states the purpose and previews the main points. The body presents typically two to four main points, each supported by evidence, examples, data, stories or visuals, in a logical order. The conclusion summarises the key points, restates the main message and ends with a memorable closing or a call to action. Q&A lets the audience ask questions; listen carefully, repeat the question, answer honestly and say "I will find out" if you don't know. Slides should support, not replace, the speaker: use few words, large fonts, high-contrast colours, relevant images and one idea per slide. Guy Kawasaki's 10-20-30 rule suggests 10 slides, 20 minutes and a font size not smaller than 30 points. Know your audience, keep to your time and avoid reading slides.

Listening, Writing and Group Skills

Active listening means paying full attention, not interrupting, nodding, asking clarifying questions and summarising what you heard. In group discussions, speak with facts, respect other views, wait for your turn and summarise. Written communication such as emails should have a clear subject line, a polite greeting, a short message and a courteous closing. In interviews and social media, tone and clarity matter. For Indian students, improving English and learning to code-switch between English and Tamil according to the audience are useful.

Practice Methods

Join debates, quizzes, elocution contests and Toastmasters; read newspapers and books to expand vocabulary; watch TED Talks and good speakers; record yourself; seek feedback; and volunteer to present in class. Even five minutes of daily speaking practice builds confidence.

Challenges and Future

Online meetings require the skills of speaking to a camera and engaging remote audiences. AI tools can give feedback on speech pace and filler words. Whatever the technology, a clear message delivered with sincerity remains central.

Quick Facts

- Ways to reduce stage fear: prepare, practise, deep breathing, positive visualisation, a strong opening and eye contact with friendly faces.
- Body language is non-verbal communication through posture, gestures, facial expressions and eye contact.
- A good presentation has an introduction, a body and a conclusion, plus Q&A.

- Toastmasters International was founded in 1924.
- Swami Vivekananda delivered his famous Chicago speech on 11 September 1893.